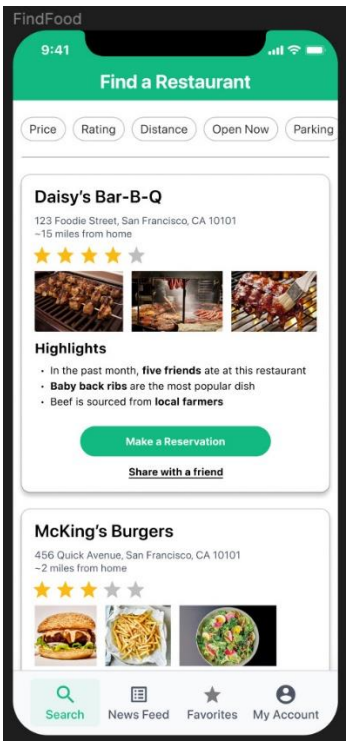
Background

UX Design is a particularly interesting process to examine in a case study. At the moment, let's pretend we're a product manager for FindFood, whose goal is to revamp the shopping experience to increase utilization (bookings/users) amongst existing users. Our current Search functionality looks like the below:



With this in mind, let's go over the basic functionality of each tab:

- Search
  - Scroll through restaurant cards
    - Filter results
      - Filter based on distinct results from each pill
    - Highlights based on social media, public user reviews, and restaurant-submitted details
  - Make reservations
    - Open a modal
      - Asks for the number of attendees
      - Shows open dates/times
      - Enter payment flow
  - Share with friends!
    - Open a modal that lets you share with in-app friends
- News Feed
  - Shows off reviews and app-generated restaurant news

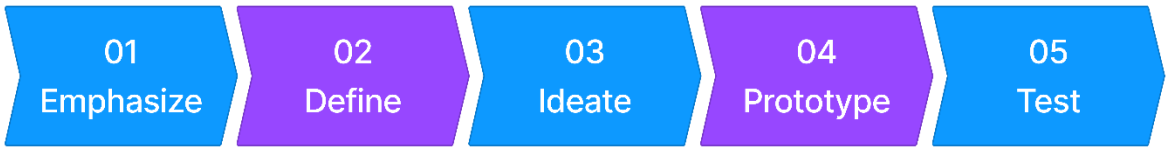
        - Sorted by recency
        - Reviews written by in-app friends
    - Tapping a card lets a user make a reservation
- Favorites
    - Displays all restaurants that you gave a 4+ star rating to
        - Can book reservations at these restaurants
- My Account
    - Displays personal info, payment details, and in-app friends

Additionally, let's look at the basic usage data associated with the app:

- Among app sessions that result in a reservation:
    - 40% included interaction with Search filters, especially price, and rating.
    - 10% included expanding restaurant pictures.
- The average user has:
    - 4 in-app friends
    - Posts 1 review every five reservations.
    - Makes 2 reservations per week
- Reservation Booking Rates
    - 70% of reservations are with restaurants that the user previously ate at
    - 30% are with "Favorites."
        - Of reservations at "Favorite" restaurants, 30% are booked through the "Favorites" page.
- Reservation timing:
    - 50% of reservations are for the same day; 80% are for some time within the next two days
    - The remaining 20% have a long rightward tail, mostly shaped around pre-booking major holidays (e.g. Valentine's Day).
- No-Show Rates:
    - 5% of same-day reservations are no shows
    - This grows to 15% if a reservation is more than 3 days away

Background

Moving forward, we will utilize the following design process:



Note that as it is impossible to test this item, the primary focus for this case is to go through the emphasize -> define -> ideate -> prototype pipeline.

Emphasize

Here, we examine the existing pain points as derived from the case study information and how the users are presently utilizing FindFood. The majority of this information was provided in the background section, so we look at the key takeaways:

- Users tend to make reservations at restaurants they already have been to, with only 30% being a result of them exploring other options
    - Despite this, a strong plurality of reservations come from the search feature
- Most reservations are made for the short term, and users are very likely to arrive at reservations made within the same or the next day.
- Users tend to only make a few reservations a week and given that they will only make 1 review every 5 reservations, that means they will only review about once every 3 weeks.

Let's also examine some quotes from users of the application to gain their perspective:

"I love FindFood because I know every restaurant in my town is on the platform, so I'm not going to be missing out on anything. Sometimes, however, the choice can be overwhelming… my partner and I will just scroll around and look at a ton of stuff and debate options for thirty minutes, and then it's basically too late to go out. I've definitely had a couple unexpected grocery store frozen dinners because of that!"

- Anton Ego

"I usually use FindFood after a long day at the office, when I know I'm going to be too tired to cook at home, to find open reservations really quickly. At this point it's muscle memory: I open the app, sort for less than 2 miles, sort for rating > 4 stars, scroll down to the third card, and book at Gregory's Greek Kitchen. If they're fully booked, I'll try Great Wall Chinese Restaurant instead. I prefer Gregory's though – it might not be the best food, but it sure does the trick."

- Colette Linguini

"It's funny, my FindFood friends aren't really people I'm close to in real life. I just sent friend requests to a couple people whose reviews I really agreed with, so I can see where they're eating and what they think. Normally I just stick to my trusty Pho 63, but when I'm feeling fancy, I'll scroll through my news feed and find a place Anton recommended that I haven't eaten at before. His 3 stars is like my 5 stars, so any place with a good review from him has never let me down."

- Auguste Gusteau

"I don't really use FindFood much at all – probably less than once a month – because I don't have an easy way to figure out whether a restaurant can meet my dietary restrictions or not. Sometimes I'll get lucky and the Highlights will mention it, but otherwise there isn't really a good way for me to filter for what I need."

- Lalo Horst

Let's look at key trends that are noticeable in these reviews:

1. Choices are overwhelming and users tend to default to specific sets of restaurants.
2. There is noted difficulty in actually using the filtering/highlight system, and it misses the mark on users who have specific dietary restrictions.
3. FindFood friends don't appear to be real-life friends, but rather strangers.
4. Overall, users seem to want an app where they can quickly find a restaurant that matches their needs, lets them make a reservation in the near future, and have options to quickly go back to restaurants that they've already been to.

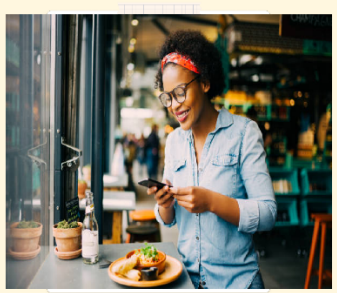
Define

In this step, I will be generating a user persona, an empathy map, a customer journey map, and a problem statement. We go through further details on each of these items on the upcoming pages.

Persona

A user persona is a useful item when considering a design as it lets one imagine a specific individual that you are designing for.

So without further ado, let's meet Marienne, our resident user!



Marienne

The Busy Body

- 27 years old
- Corporate Strategy Consultant
- New York City

Bio

Marienne is a working professional who has always prioritized her career growth. She worked hard in University and acquired an MBA from a top-tier school, which she used to transition to being a consultant. As she's grown up, she's rekindled a desire to try out new things and explore, especially given her role's location in New York City. She has a few friends who she usually hands out with at one bar that they're all used to. She'd love to show them new places, but she struggles knowing which places to go.

Vegetarian | Risk Adverse | Hard Worker

Motivations

- Being able to grab a comfort meal after a long day of work
- Avoiding risks, being able to find new foods based on trusted reviews
- Trying out something new on rare occasions
- Showing off some places to her friends

Goals

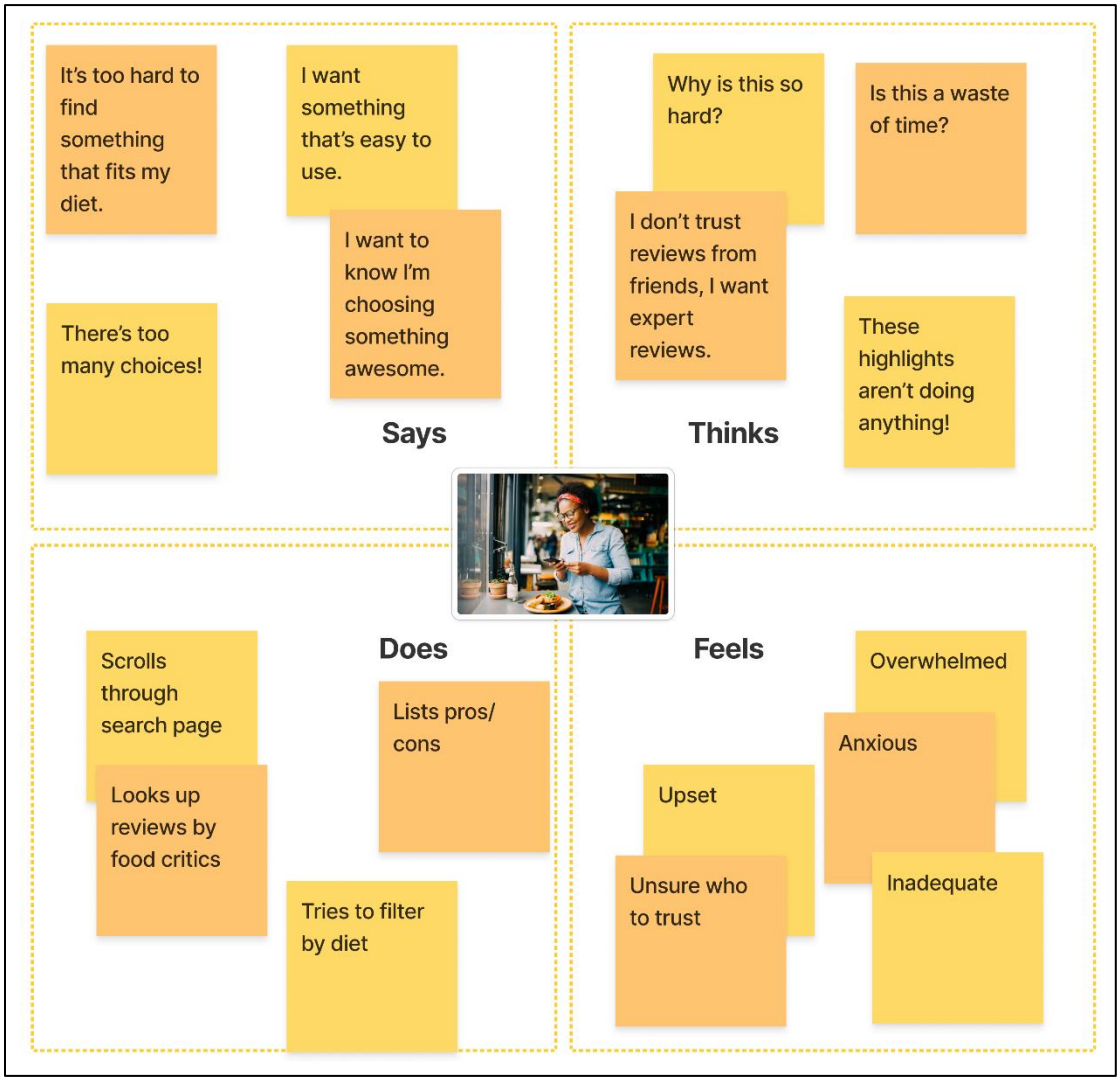
- Make fast reservations, at places she knows of
- Be able to easily filter out restaurants that do not match her diet
- Be recommended good options without searching
- Parse through reviews to see which restaurants are good

Pain points and frustrations

- The current filters aren't enough to help her decide where to go
- Without in-app friends, it's hard for her to find reviews that she can trust
- Highlights don't address her dietary restrictions
- At comfort locations, the reservation system is too lengthy
- Hard to show off restaurants to friends who don't use the app
- There are always too many options shown to make a decision

Empathy Map

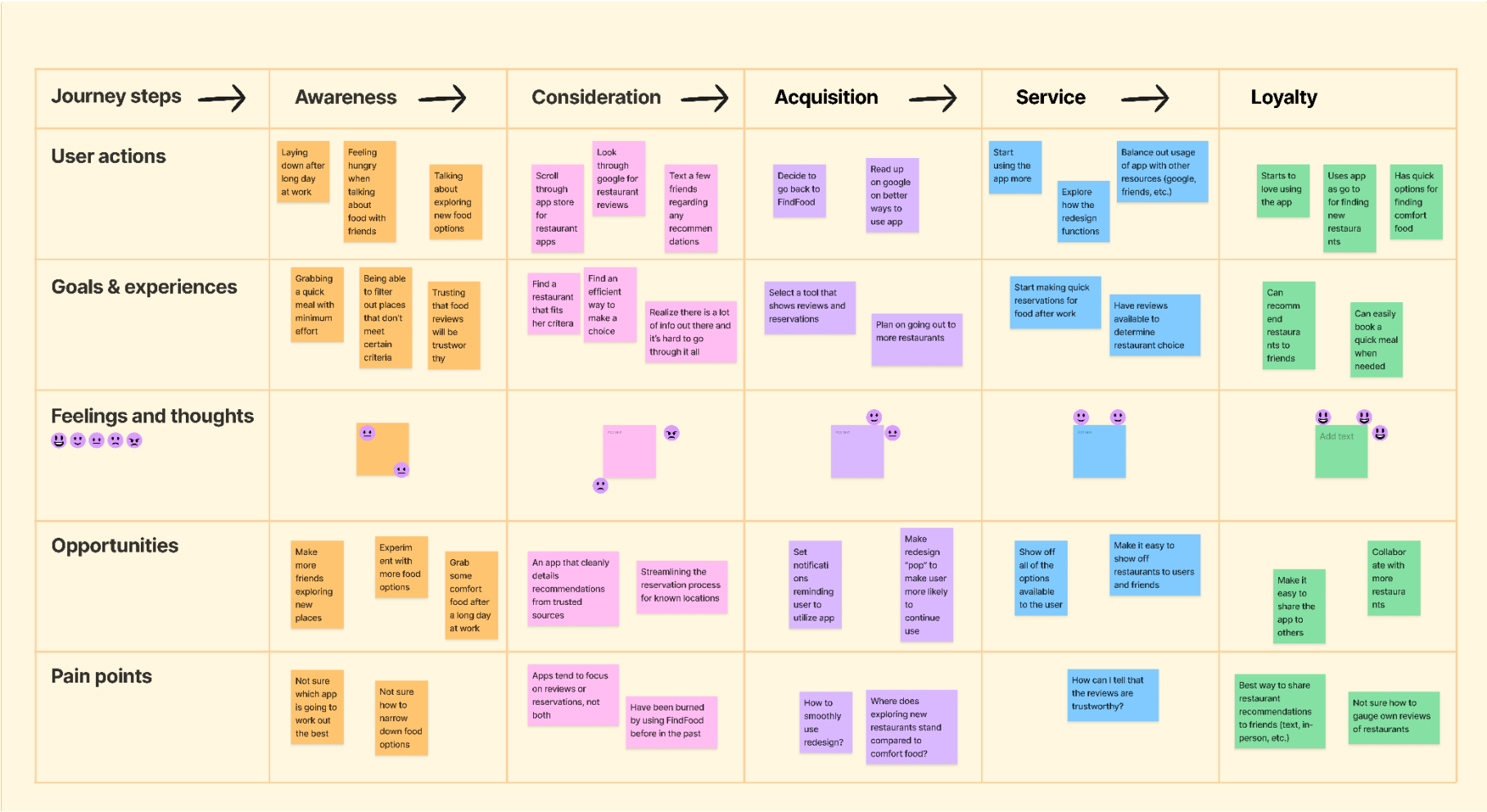
Now, we have an idea of who Marienne is. However, what does her typical day look like as she's using the app? What is going on inside her brain? For this, we utilize an empathy map.



Marienne wants to choose some restaurants that she can show off to friends, as well as have the option to find some comfort food. While she's very competent in her role, she feels anxious and inadequate when she's unable to find anything on the app and is embarrassed about it. She's unsure if adding random strangers as in-app friends is a good strategy, but she doesn't know what to do as she's uncertain if her friends can properly review restaurants.

Customer Journey Map

If Marienne were to return to FindFood after the redesign, what would that look like and how does it accomplish her goals and remove her pains? Using a customer journey map, we can have a visual storyline of how Marienne is going to engage with FindFood.



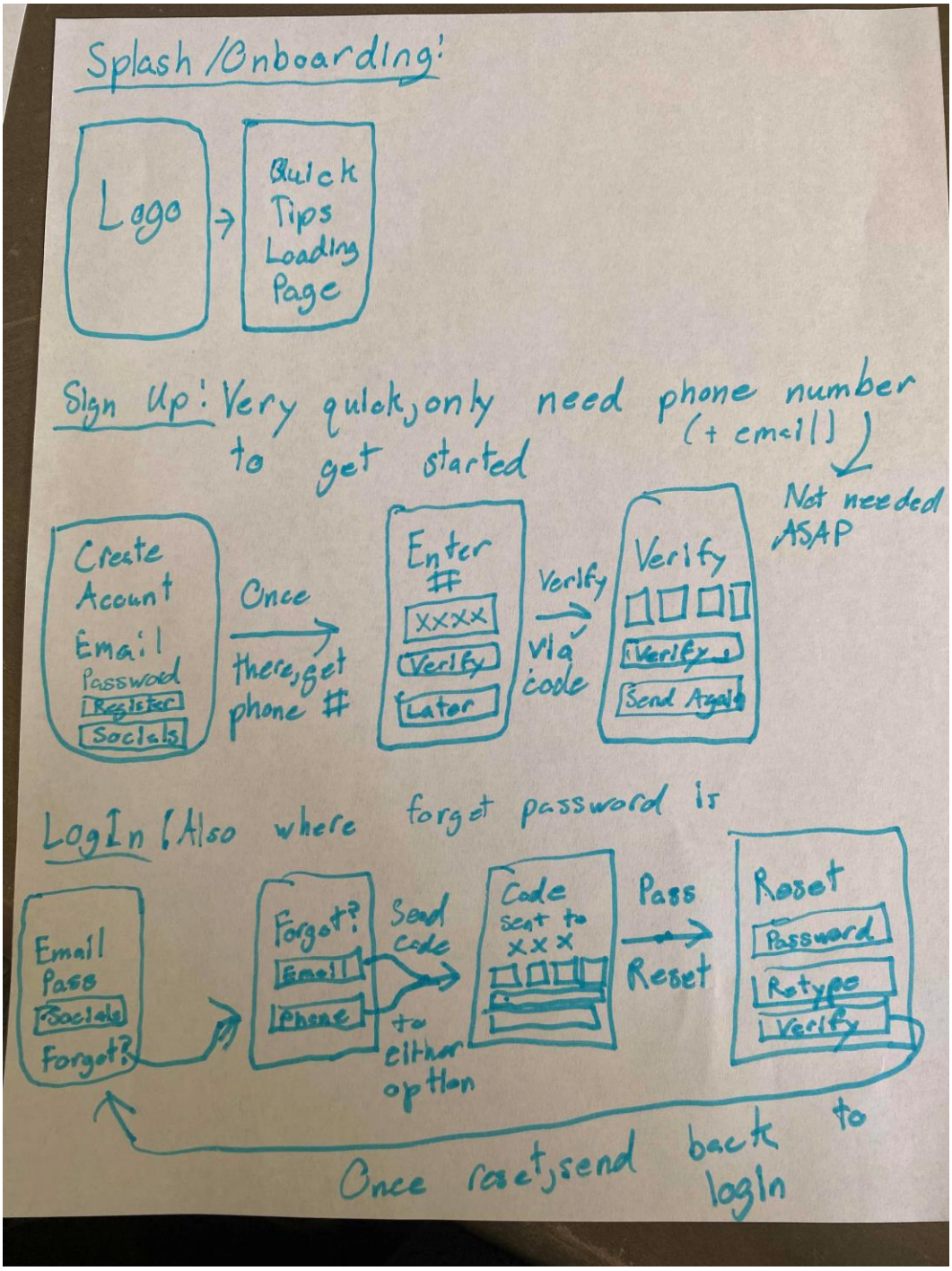
In this journey, Marienne goes through the process of rediscovering FindFood after its redesign, after exploring different options. The image above showcases how she learns to love FindFood after its redesign and becomes a power user of the application.

Problem Statement

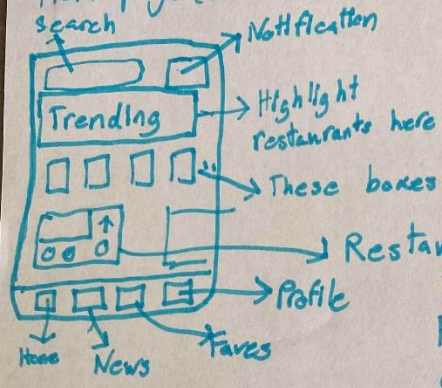
After this initial research phase, we come down to a specific problem statement: **"How do we encourage users to use the application more and make it easy to do so?**

Ideate

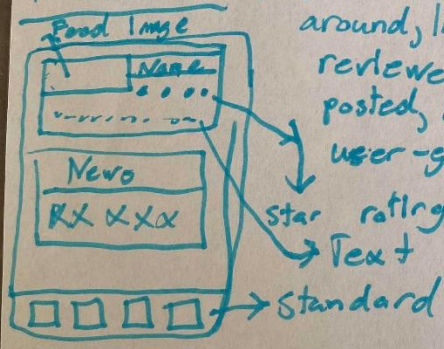
In this step, we'll go through a quick series of sketches and ideation on how this application is going to work. For this reason, these sketches will be very quickly drawn out on paper as they are preliminary low-fidelity models of the final idea. These sketches are shown below:



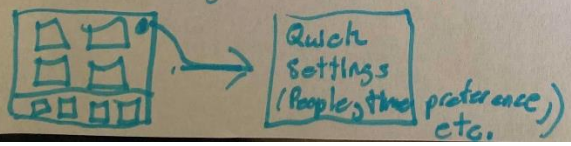
Homepage (aka search):



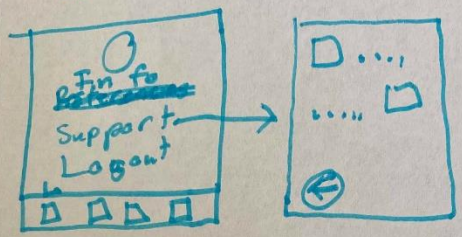
News Feed: Now showcases reviews from all around, lets you star certain reviewers. Some news is posted, but much less than user-generated reviews



Favorites: Here are favorites, If you reserve via this page, you can have quick settings for reservations



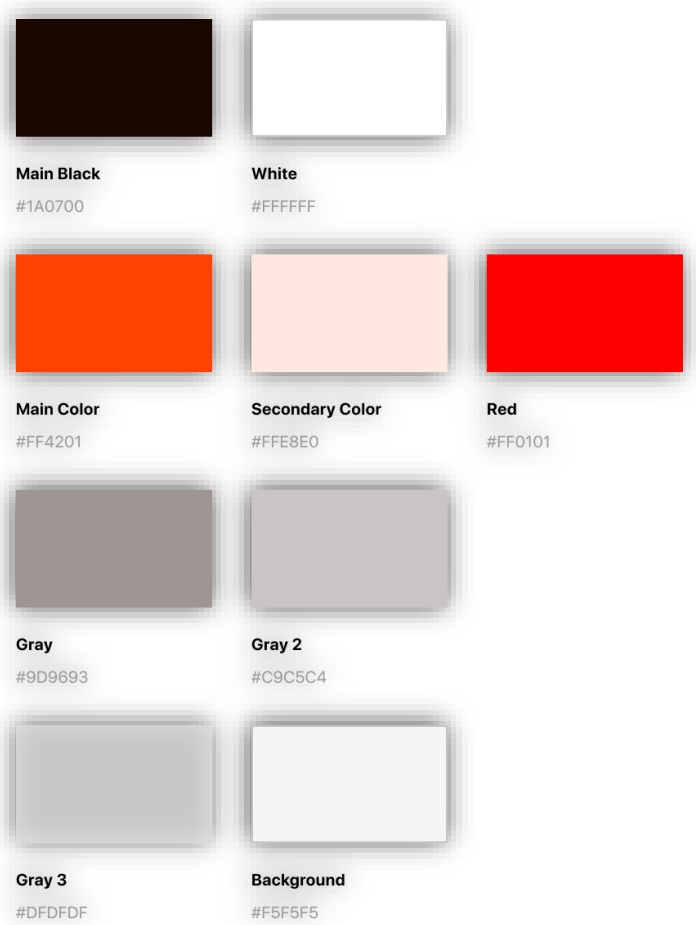
Profile: Basic profile info, access to customer support. Support uses basic chat window.



Of note of these sketches, there has been a removal of the in-app friend feature and news feed for a public forum feature that includes all of the reviews in a region. This is driven by the fact that the majority of users didn't actually utilize reviews by their friends, but rather reviews by strangers whom they trusted. Additionally, the search page has been redesigned to focus on simplicity, giving users a series of trending restaurants and food-type divisions. The text highlights have been removed for simpler to comprehend icon highlights (which a user can tap to get more text information). Finally, of note, the favorites page allows a user to quickly make a reservation based on their quick settings (though timing selection will still be relevant). With these initial sketches in mind, we finally move on to the prototype of our redesign.

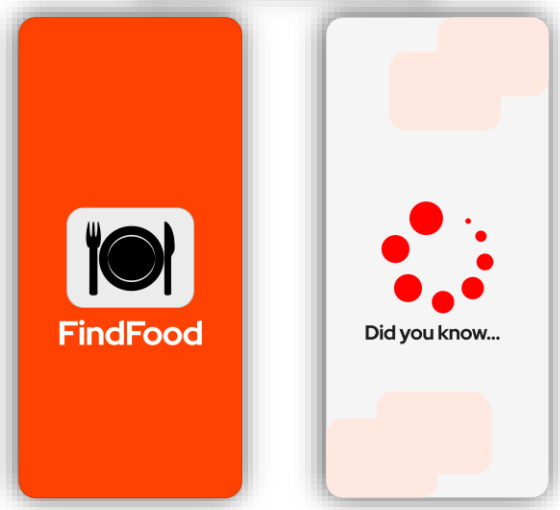
Prototype

Recent research suggests that warm colors attract more overall interest in food items compared to colder colors [1]. Whilst the current green does stand out as a warmer one, the classical warmer color of red may work as a better option to entice users to act on their hunger urges. We, therefore, follow the below coloring guide in the design of our application:

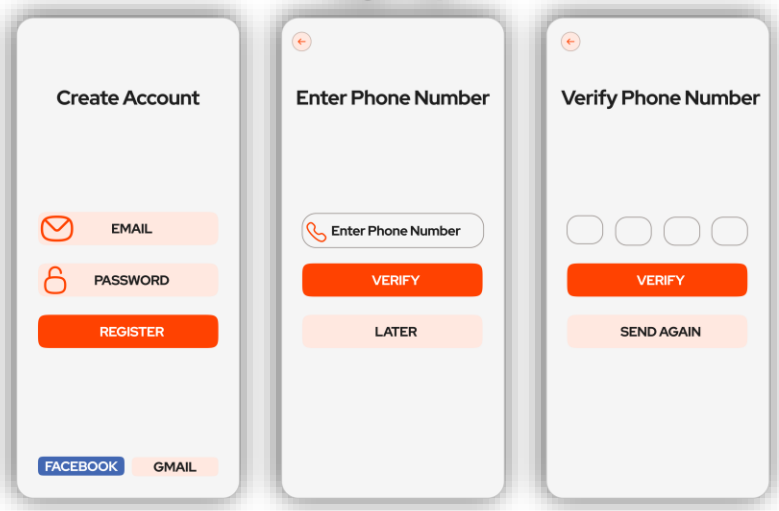


Taking into account all of these aspects that we've explored throughout this exploration, we move onto the final redesign. Let's put together everything into one cohesive prototype (as designed in Figma).

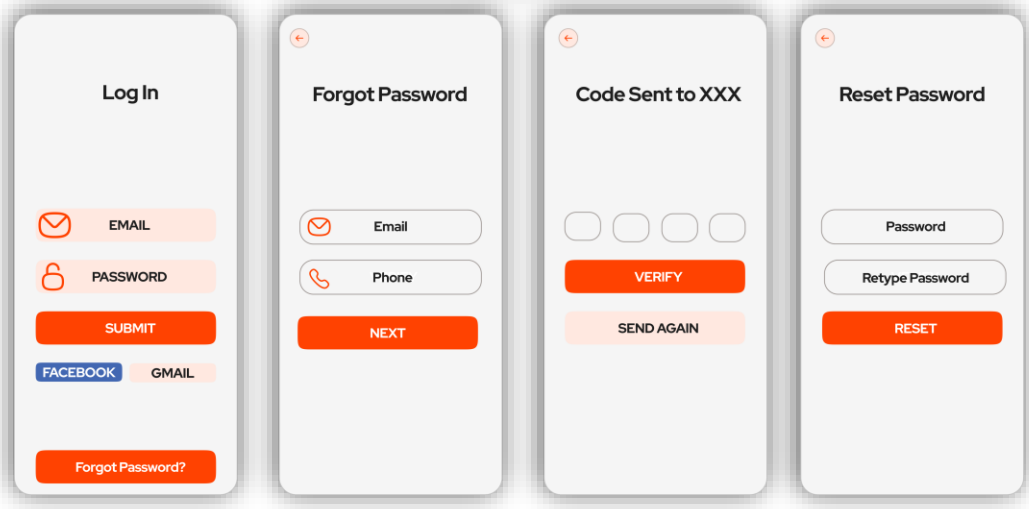
Splash/Onboarding



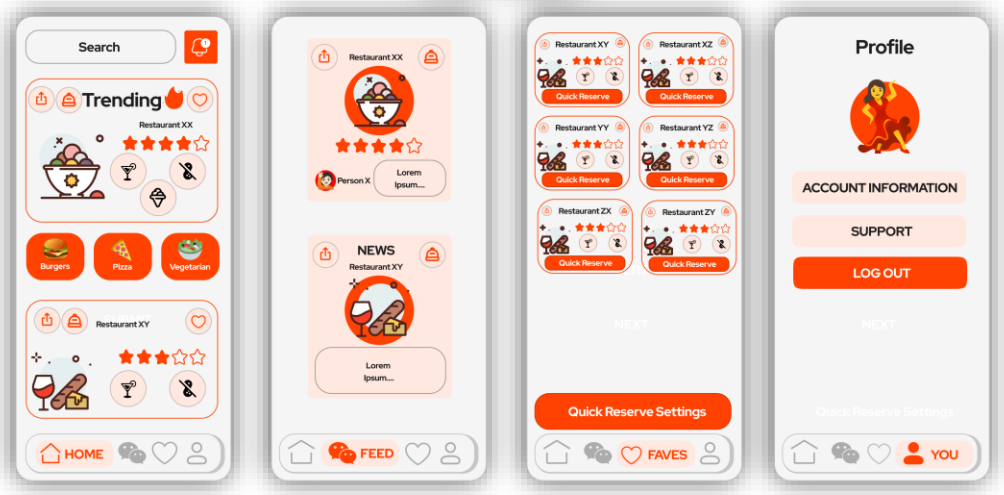
Sign-Up



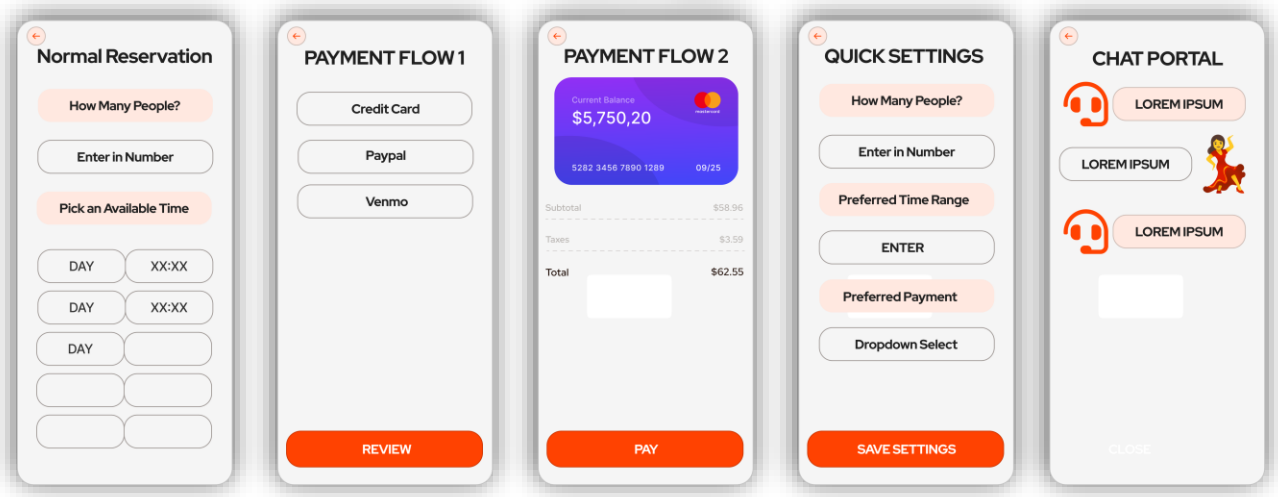
Log In



Main Pages



Extra Pages



Overall, this new design substantially streamlines the process for users, reduces options in order to avoid decision paralysis, and provides the user more options to quickly make a reservation or examine reviews by users that they trust.

Reflections

Moving forward, this prototype will need to undergo usability testing to examine if all functionality works as anticipated. Additionally, there will need to be collaboration with engineering teams to examine the difficulties associated with various components of the design. For example, while the variable button selection is aesthetically pleasing, is it worth the engineering time to implement it in the MVP? This design serves as an initial foundation for further work to be done, and will require input from an engineer and a designer to validate all of the components.

Works Cited

[1] Huang, Jingyi. (2023). A Study on the Effect of Color on Human Food Perception. Journal of Education, Humanities and Social Sciences. 10. 225-230. 10.54097/ehss.v10i.7021.